

TAB 33



Board of Education Report

File #: Res-017-25/26, **Version:** 1**Agenda Date:** 10/14/2025**In Control:** Board of Education

Ms. Gonez - Resilient Schools: Extreme Heat Mitigation & Disaster Preparedness at LAUSD (Res-017-25/26)
(For Action November 18, 2025)

Whereas, The increasing frequency and severity of extreme heat events, wildfires, and other climate driven disasters demand immediate action, and local agencies like the Los Angeles Unified School District cannot afford to wait for state or federal intervention alone, but must act with urgency to safeguard the health, safety, and learning conditions of students and staff;

Whereas, The impacts of the climate crisis fall disproportionately on low-income communities and communities of color, whose neighborhoods often lack access to cooling systems, tree canopy, shade, and resilient infrastructure, making it imperative that the District lead with equity by prioritizing policies and investments that protect those most vulnerable;

Whereas, The District has invested in making our campuses greener and more resilient, but many campuses still have outdated cooling infrastructure and lack shade and climate resilient designs, which can lead to disrupted instruction and negative impacts on student learning;

Whereas, Beyond the significant detriments to health and wellbeing, there are serious concerns around the impacts of heat exposure to children's learning. A recent systemic review published in July 2025 in POS Climate found that extended exposure to heat impairs students' cognitive abilities, negatively affecting their academic performance;

Whereas, Artificial turf adds to the impacts of extreme heat, since it absorbs and retains far more solar radiation than natural grass creating surface temperatures reaching in excess of 160 degrees, exacerbating the urban heat island effect, with growing body of research and health and environmental experts expressing concerns over the potential for harm including burns, chemical exposure, and other injuries (L.A. Times, September, 2025);

Whereas, The growing impacts of extreme heat demand a comprehensive approach to protect the health and safety of students and staff, requiring the District to evaluate and address multiple vulnerabilities at once including the environmental and health risks posed by artificial turf, the strain of aging HVAC systems during heat waves, and the uneven access to critical protections such as shade structures and hydration stations, so that all campuses are adequately prepared to mitigate the dangers of rising temperatures;

Whereas, Shade, through trees, canopies, and other natural or built features, is one of the most effective and immediate protections and the District's facilities division has committed to a goal of at least 20% shade coverage when undertaking campus greening projects, it is critical to assess current progress toward the benchmark and adopt a clear actionable strategy to meet it; and

Whereas, Funds from voter-approved bond measures including LAUSD's local facilities bond Measure US, and state bond measures Proposition 2 and Proposition 4 create an opportunity to further prioritize District capital investments to increase the build out of renewable energy technologies, such as solar photovoltaic panels and battery energy storage systems on District property to sustainably power upgraded HVAC systems, ensuring long-term cost savings and climate resilience for campuses; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Los Angeles Unified School District shall update its disaster preparedness plan to explicitly address escalating threats posed by extreme heat and related climate emergencies including wildfires. This process shall be carried out in coordination with all relevant District divisions, labor partners, school site staff, families, students, and community stakeholders, to ensure the plan reflects on the ground needs, and report back to the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District in 90 days;

Resolved further, That the plan will include protocols for protecting student and staff safety, operational procedures including clear metrics for shifting school schedules and considering closures, guidance on continuity of instruction, communication (e.g. notification systems for staff and families), protocols for dissemination of information such as the readiness of air filtration systems, and any other necessary information that can be shared in coordination with City and County emergency response agencies, and necessary training for staff on the updated protocols;

Resolved further, Considering the need to ensure our campus infrastructure can address extreme heat events, the District shall:

- Accelerate HVAC modernization projects, prioritizing campuses using equity-based criteria (such as SENI ranking and communities most impacted by extreme heat and environmental injustices), with the goal to replace or modernize no fewer than 5000 HVAC units per year, with annual progress reports to the Board;
- Prioritize, to the extent feasible, climate-friendly technologies as part of the accelerated HVAC modernization projects including heat pumps;
- Provide an update on progress on the District's strategy for the deployment of additional heat mitigation measures such as expanded tree canopy, shade structures, hydration stations, and misting systems to ensure students and staff have access to cooling space and protection from heat, including how the deployment strategy prioritizes communities most impacted by extreme heat;
- Prepare and present an interim mitigation plan, because many schools with aging HVAC systems cannot immediately receive full modernization or shade installations leaving students and staff vulnerable during peak heat events;
- Prioritize funding from Measure US, Proposition 2, and Proposition 4 to address the heat mitigation goals and the clean energy goals as outlined in the Board resolution Transitioning LAUSD to 100% Clean, Renewable Energy (Res 018-19/20) to enhance air quality and protect the health of students, staff, and families;

Resolved further, That the District's Office of Governmental Relations will advocate with State leaders for the creation of a maximum indoor temperature standard for public schools in California, including for classrooms and spaces where students, staff, and families regularly use such as cafeterias,

auditoriums, and parent centers, and for the allocation of relevant State bond funding to ensure that all public schools can meet this standard, with a prioritization on schools in communities most impacted by extreme heat;

Resolved further, That in recognition of the significant environmental and climate consequences of artificial turf, including the release of microplastics, into soil and waterways, and its absorption and radiation of heat that exacerbates the urban heat island effect, the District shall update its policy to:

- Prohibit installation of artificial turf at early education centers, primary centers, elementary schools, and middle schools,
- Prioritize the replacement of existing artificial turf at early education centers (EECs) and Elementary schools, in particular, as they reach their end-of-life with grass, plants, or natural materials;
- Identify funding to conduct a study that includes:
 - A cost-benefit analysis taking into account the public health impacts, injury liability to the District, environmental impacts such as water contamination, the impacts of climate hazards such as extreme heat and rain storms, the costs of remediation, waste management and costs to our waste stream of artificial turf versus natural grass playing fields;
 - Data collected from monitoring exposure to artificial turf in high-heat conditions (e.g. scheduling early morning/evening activity, heat advisories, cooling interventions);
 - Stakeholder input gathered from labor partners, school staff, students, families, and community members;

Resolved further, That the study shall inform staff recommendations for a policy update pertaining to synthetic turf as part of high school competitive athletic facilities to be presented to the Board within 120 days; and, be it, finally

Resolved, That regular updates on extreme heat mitigation and the District's response shall be included in the annual report of the Office of Eco-Sustainability.